

Critical Reflection on Programming as of Friday, 7th October 2022
Parishka Kiara Pillay
1632482

Programming is probably my most favoured caveat in the much-overlooked realm of practical application in architecture. It is also my greatest personal challenge.

Heterotopia, temporality, liminality, pattern languages, deconstruction seem to overlap between my general understanding prior to the reading, as well as within the reading itself - I comment mostly on Foucault, as the concept is the most challenging to grasp.

The principles outlined regarding what constitutes heterotopia are relevant to almost any aspect of architecture, an "Othered" collective of juxtapositions, suspended between growth place and time.

This very much embodies the threshold/third space mentality postcolonial theorists have used deconstruction philosophy to articulate.

There exists almost an insecurity of being - as Alan Watts has described the paradox of living: that which considers itself foolish is wise, and insecure is secure, etc. Hence, a heterotopia becomes a utopia in its sincere lack of trying to be as such. An acceptance of entropy and lived encounters between diverse patterns.

Alexander's "a city is not a tree" refers to the basics of agent-network theory wherein an action or set of actions constitute a subset of objects in an urban setting. For instance, a subset of a bus stop, a newspaper stand and a coffee shop at the same corner, allows for varied interactions between multiple end users converging and diverging to use one or all elements in different stages. a subset becomes the complementary concept to the arrangement Foucault refers to: the arrangement of "rest" being the-bed-the-bedroom-the-lounge etc. extended to the bench in external spaces, for example.

This lends itself to a cross-examination between subsets and arrangements that make for interesting ideas in the act of programming itself.

Understanding and starting to engage human behaviour with regards to its own culture and responses to (previously-considered universal design) the spatial experience, allows one to rewrite the genus loci/cognitive map that encodes the significance of place in the mind of the collective end users, or multiple thereof.

The more varied, and potentially discordant these engagements become, the closer to heterotopic environments we may approach.

In special regard to my mock-thesis, as well as personal experience in psychiatric facilities, the ideas of liminality within trauma are starting to unfold within the heterotopic condition.

I am also especially interested in the ideas of agency, ownership and temporality regarding power relations within a heterotopia. the fact remains that these cannot belong to any true singular power, such is the requirement for it to function. The ever-evolving nature of the

microcosm must constantly flux towards its multiple new owners, however temporary. The identity of the space must be changeable - and its practical spatial programming, fluid - to accommodate the cultural needs of demographics that may come and go. This suggests a type of temporality, alluding to the illusion the reading mentions, where a place exists as one thing and then another, or sometimes may cease to exist completely when not in particular use. Perhaps it is a space which hides itself until activated in a particular way.

All in all, this seemingly unachievable, magickal entity is a place of belonging that the subaltern yearns for, an adventure for myself included.